

Cliffs of Dover -- Eric Johnson

Bass: Harley Benton P/J, 5-string, passive. Full board.

From *Ah Via Musicom* (1990), ~133 BPM.

This is a guitar showcase, so the bass job is to stay tight, articulate, and out of the way of Eric Johnson's runs -- hi-fi and clean, not dirty. Most of the tune is a driving, uptempo groove locked to the main riff and the fast unison lines. There's one exception: the mid-tune interlude, where the band drops back and the guitar goes into a more spacious, atmospheric passage before the reprise and outro shred.

CTL off = the main driving groove (most of the song). CTL on = the interlude, where things open up.

GP-5 settings

Module order: NR -> PRE -> DST -> AMP -> CAB -> EQ -> MOD -> DLY -> RVB.

NR -- Gate

- THRE: 15
- Always on. Low threshold -- this tone stays clean and hi-fi, nothing to gate out.

PRE -- Off

- Compression duties are handled by the Donner Ultimate Comp on the board (see below).

DST -- Off

AMP -- Mess Bass, always on. Gain 40, VOL 65, Bass 55, Middle 60, Treble 65.

CAB -- User IR 4 (EBS410), always on. VOL 60.

- No separate drive stage -- this tune calls for clarity and note definition, not grit, and stacking a gain stage would just work against that.

EQ -- Bass EQ 2

- 50Hz: +2, 120Hz: 0, 400Hz: -3, 800Hz: +3, 4.5kHz: +4, VOL: 55
- Always on, same for both CTL states.
- -3 at 400Hz cuts the boxiness that would otherwise mud up fast passages. +3 at 800Hz and +4 at 4.5kHz push the pick/finger attack and top-end sparkle -- this needs to sit crisp and present under Johnson's famously hi-fi guitar tone, not warm and rounded off.

MOD -- B-Chorus -- On CTL

- Depth: 25, Rate: 0.4Hz, VOL: 55
- CTL off: bypassed (main groove -- dry and direct). CTL on: engaged (interlude).
- Light touch -- just enough shimmer to match the more atmospheric character of the interlude section, not a drenched chorus effect.

DLY -- Off

- Not used. Keeping this simple -- one atmospheric element (the RVB below) is enough for the interlude without cluttering a section that's meant to feel like a held breath before the outro.

RVB -- Room -- On CTL

- Mix: 25, Decay: 35, Trail: On
- CTL off: bypassed (main groove -- tight and dry, right in the pocket with the drums). CTL on: engaged (interlude).
- Opens the space up for the interlude's more atmospheric feel, then closes right back down as the tune ramps back to full energy.

AMP: Mess Bass (Mesa/Boogie Bass 400) + CAB: EBS410 IR (User IR 4)

Rebuilt 2026-09-18 off the GP-5's own AMP + a loaded IR -- NAMs are off for now (Valeton N->S volume issue, device-side). The old NAM was the clean-voiced Darkglass Harmonic Booster into an Aguilar DB 751 -- no grit, just a warm, hi-fi boost. Mess Bass at the same low gain gives the same clean, articulate character; EBS410 is ir.md's own recommendation for clean bass tones, which suits a part that has to stay present without ever competing with Eric Johnson's guitar for space.

- Gain: 40
- VOL: 65
- Bass: 55
- Middle: 60
- Treble: 65
- CAB VOL: 60.

CTL summary

- **CTL Off -- Main groove.** The driving uptempo sections and fast unison lines that make up most of the song. Dry, tight, clean.
- **CTL On -- Interlude.** Chorus and Room reverb engage together, opening the tone up to match the more spacious, atmospheric passage before the reprise.
- Engage CTL going into the interlude, disengage coming out of it back into the driving main groove.

Full pedalboard (signal chain order)

1. Flamma FS-08 Octave -- Bypassed

- Footswitch off. This part needs a single, clean fundamental to stay articulate through fast passages -- an octave stack would clutter it.

2. Donner Ultimate Comp -- Engaged

- COMP: 55
- TONE: 60
- LEVEL: 60
- Mode: TREBLE
- Moderate compression keeps note-to-note consistency even through the tune's faster runs, without squashing the natural attack. TREBLE mode keeps that attack bright and audible ahead of the NAM.

3. Donner Stylish Fuzz -- Bypassed

- Footswitch off. No fuzz anywhere in this build -- it would clash with the clean, hi-fi character the whole tune is built around.

4. Joyo Tidal Wave -- Bypassed

- Footswitch off, Drive/Blend not engaged. The NAM's own harmonic-boost character is the only "enhancement" this tone needs -- stacking another gain stage would just soften the note definition this tune depends on.

5. Joyo Narcissus -- Bypassed

- Footswitch off. The GP-5's own B-Chorus already covers the interlude's chorus needs -- running both at once would just get thick and washy where this section wants shimmer, not mud.

6. Valeton GP-5 -- see settings above.